vehicles grind to a halt as they came under heavy fire about a kilometre south of Bridge 2. Trapped on the road, unable to even get out of the vehicles and make a run for it, vehicle after vehicle was systematically destroyed by the Chinese. Under orders not to take prisoners, the Chinese herded surviving troops next to burning vehicles and shot them. The entire column was wiped out. The Chinese then withdrew from the ambush site and took up flanking positions—they knew infantry columns were following down the same road.

As the leading elements of 2 Sikh LI reached the site, they were met by the ghastly sight of the dead and the dying littered amongst the remains of burnt and charred vehicles. Hardly had the infantry column reached the spot when it came under withering fire from dominant positions on both sides of the valley. The leading elements stood no chance, completely caught out in the open as it were.

The remainder of the column was hopelessly trapped, left with no choice but to try and push forward along the road towards Dirang Dzong. Using their own 2-inch mortars while calling in 3-inch mortar fire support from 13 Dogra at Senge, the men fought tenaciously and cleared the Chinese from the slopes for about half a kilometre. The column then came under lethal fire from a Chinese post that was situated on a feature below Nyukmadong village. A platoon of 1 Sikh under Lieutenant Surinder Dagur was pushed forward to take on the well-entrenched Chinese. Though the platoon succeeded in its objective, the young officer and most of his men were killed.

As the day progressed, this was the pattern of fighting as a series of Chinese ambushes had to be dealt with. Each time a section or a platoon under one of the surviving officers would move forward. Each time, they would clear the Chinese only to run into yet another ambush. Very few junior officers with the marching column would make it to the end of the day, sacrificing themselves one by one in a desperate bid to break through the Chinese stranglehold on the road. By last light, there was very little command and control left, and as darkness descended, small parties of the surviving troops made for the mountain range south of the Khouma River, hoping to escape across the border into Bhutan.

Chinese troops that had bypassed Se-la and got behind the Indians initially seemed to be under instructions not to take any prisoners. Accordingly, their mopping up parties ruthlessly went about bayoneting the